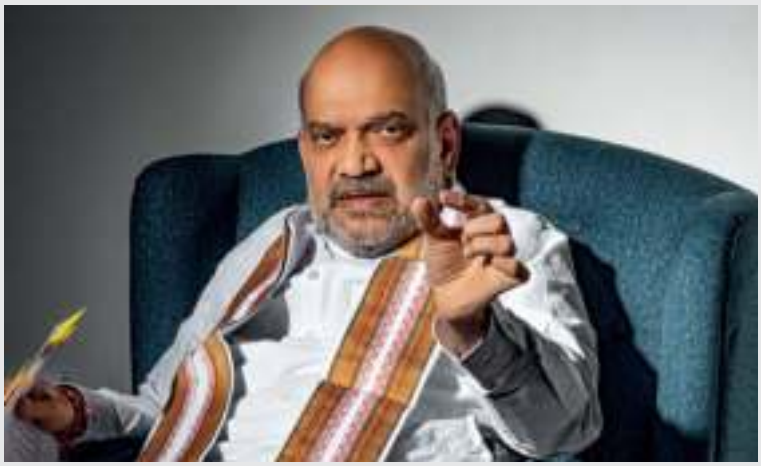
INTERVIEW

"NDA will win with a majority of 160+ seats"

On the campaign trail in Madhubani, Aaj Tak's Anjana Om Kashyap caught up with Union home minister Amit Shah. Excerpts:



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

On the NDA's prospects: We will win with a 160-plus majority. All the alliance partners will have similar strike rates.

On the NDA Sankalp Patra's promise of creating one crore job opportunities: In the past 11 years, we have strengthened the infrastructure for industry, be it roads, bridges or power plants. We have also set up a number of factories—two textile hubs, a fertiliser plant in Barauni. Bihar is already the biggest producer of ethanol in the country. If we consider all that we have already done, it's already created employment worth over 7 crore man-days. Our promise is backed by arithmetic and planning.

On finding the money to fund promises: You don't need a government budget to finance private sector jobs. We have spent Rs 18.7 lakh crore on infrastructure. The jobs will come from private firms that have come because roads, airports, bridges are ready; the government jobs will come to support them.

On whether Rs 10,000 dole to women amounts to buying of votes: If 25 women pool in their Rs 10,000, they will have Rs 2.5 lakh, which can serve as seed money for a Rs 20 lakh loan and help them start a small business. The Opposition may call it buying of votes but we see it as empowering women.

On blaming Tejashwi for Lalu's 'jungle raj': Who is Tejashwi? Lalu's son. Who hands out tickets? Lalu Yadav. He still runs the party. The RJD's ideology is *lathmar* (wielding the stick). If they win, I can assure you, it will be a return to 'jungle raj'.

On a Sita temple in Sitamarhi: The party and its workers believe culture and religion are a big part of our social life. We will not set it aside for the sake of appeasement.

On there being no vacancy for CM or PM and not calling a press meet to declare Nitish CM candidate: What is a press meet? We have said it at public functions. Isn't that enough? ■

trated. At the same time, the return of Upendra Kushwaha and his Rashtriya Lok Morcha to the NDA fold shores up another slice of the OBC arithmetic—his namesake Kushwaha cohort.

But there are still worries. Apart from the MGB, there is concern that Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraaj project could siphon off some of the youth and migrant workers' vote which might otherwise lean towards the NDA. There is also no denying the fatigue from two decades in power. Welfare cheques and freebies can shore up the turnout, but they are not a solution for long pent-up aspirations. The JD(U)'s diminished organisational heft also means Nitish increasingly relies on senior partner BJP's poll machinery—an asymmetry that could create friction. Finally, in triangular contests where the anti-RJD votes split, outcomes could become unpredictable.

Steady on the Steering

Nitish's long-standing outreach programmes for the EBCs and women have translated into voter caches that opponents have found difficult to dislodge. Even as rumours about fitness circulate, the image that sticks is of a stabilising influence rather than a spent leader.

On the stump, Nitish's rhetoric performs double duty, harking back to the litany of achievements even as it points to a better future, incremental as it might be. This is the language of stewardship: we have tended to your affairs; allow us to continue. But the speeches are also defensive. 'Jungle raj', once a slogan, is now part of the campaign lexicon. It's a blunt message, but in many parts of Bihar, it still resonates.

If he wins, history is likely to record Nitish as Bihar's long-serving reformer—flawed, flexible but undeniably a legend. If he loses, his career will be read as a cautionary tale: a leader who reinvented himself so many times that identity became both scaffolding and hazard. Whatever the outcome, this election, the grammar of politics in Bihar will change. The state will have opened another chapter. ■